

Tips: Differentiating a Good Source from a Bad Source

Navigating the vast sea of information online for your school projects or papers requires a keen eye for distinguishing between reliable sources and misleading ones. Here are streamlined strategies to ensure you're referencing quality material:

- **Examine the Website's Domain:**
 - Domains ending in **.edu** (educational institutions) and **.gov** (government agencies) typically signal credibility.
 - **.org** domains often belong to non-profits, which can be reliable, but it's wise to assess their agenda or bias.
 - For **.com** domains, especially from established news outlets, a bit of scrutiny is necessary to confirm their trustworthiness.
- **Evaluate the Authorship:**
 - Identify the author. An anonymous piece may require a critical second look.
 - Assess whether the author supports their assertions with data from authoritative sources or if it's predominantly opinion-based.
 - Consider the publication date, especially for topics that evolve rapidly, such as technology or science.
- **Corroborate with Other Sources:**
 - When you stumble upon intriguing facts, validate them by checking other reputable sites.
 - Discrepancies between sources require further investigation to uncover what is accurate.
- **Use Some Sources as Preliminary Reference Points Only:**
 - Wikipedia and similar platforms serve well for a broad overview but vary in accuracy due to their user-generated content.
 - Blogs, forums, and chat rooms can offer diverse perspectives but should be approached with caution and supplemented with more reliable sources for academic work.

Source: UTEP Connect. 2017. 4 ways to differentiate a good source from a bad source. <https://www.utep.edu/extendeduniversity/utepconnect/blog/march-2017/4-ways-to-differentiate-a-good-source-from-a-bad-source.html>.